

**A Reply
to
Professor R. Nielsen**

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Professor of Philosophy

Translated from the Danish by Hans Halvorson

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In the Postscript that Professor Nielsen has appended to his “popular” lectures from Christiania, he concludes with a declaration, drawn up in authoritative form and luxuriously furnished with the trinkets of street language. Professor Nielsen will not reply, even should a fifth and a sixth assailant join the four whom there is supposed to be no sense in answering — of whom, however, the two, the two ordained men, would perhaps, in accordance with the Professor’s old and ever-recurring love of theology, have been answered. Professor Nielsen withdraws majestically with that declaration, and now, enthroned upon the Olympus of his two-peaked logic and shrouded in the cloud-banks of his theory of faith, he will at most hurl — not exactly the Cloud-gatherer’s lightning, but that species of projectile which drives off the enemy although it can neither wound nor harm.

Then came the “fifth assailant” with his book, and Professor Nielsen made haste, without waiting for the book’s completion — which was not, after all, like Prof. N.’s philosophy of religion, first to await the completion of the Logic of the Fundamental Ideas some 114½ years hence^{*)} and so appear at the next *calendæ græcæ*, but was to be given this year; and he wrote a piece bearing the title: Hr. Professor Brøchners filosofiske Kritik, *gjennemseet* af R. Nielsen.

Now is this piece a reply, or merely a projectile, or is it a higher dialectical unity of reply and non-reply, of reply and projectile? What follows will give the reader the premises from which he must then draw the conclusion himself.

In my criticism of Professor Nielsen’s theory I had established that the determination which was the theory’s chief cornerstone — the *absolute heterogeneity* which Prof. Nielsen accented so strongly, and which the echoes repeated in chorus — expressed something self-contradictory and impossible.

I had shown how this concept, which Prof. Nielsen could not hold fast and would not give up, brought confusion in everywhere, and bred of itself a spawn of contradictions, which I enumerated in my book, p. 213 f.^{*)}

I had shown how the Nielsenian theory, while it undermines the ground of knowledge, annihilates the ethical and corrupts the religious.

I had shown how this theory is in Prof. N. an empty thought-experiment, without root in a personality, without truth in a life’s actuality.

I had, with respect to the scientific work to which Prof. N. points back as the foundation of his theory of faith, established its dualism, and pointed out a thoroughgoing

^{*)}The calculation is made in Dr. Heegaard’s book: Prof. R. N.’s Lære om Tro og Viden, p. 94 f.

^{*)}Prof. N. concedes (the piece, p. 3, at the foot) that I have pointed out *real* contradictions, but he avoids saying which. Might it perhaps be, among others, the *absolute heterogeneity*?

confusion in the fundamental concepts, a want of scientific form. I had established the impossibility of the projected “inverted” science: the philosophy of religion (in the Nielsenian sense), the one by which a distant future was to be made blessed.

To all this Prof. Nielsen has been able to answer *nothing*^{**}): it stands, now that his piece has appeared, as before, unrefuted. And yet, if only the doctrine of the *absolute heterogeneity* must be given up by Prof. N., then the battle is lost for him; for this *absolute heterogeneity*, “on account of which” the reconciliation of faith and knowledge in the same consciousness is to become possible, carries, as has been conceded often enough, the *whole doctrine*. But the word itself is avoided in Prof. N.’s book.

A reply to the attack Prof. N. has thus not given; to that extent he is in good accord with his declaration. But what, then, has been done in the piece over the 52 pages?

There is, in the first place, an attempt to deny the correctness of my account of Nielsen’s theory — which, moreover, I am not readily permitted to call a theory. Well, about the name I will not quarrel; only I come to be a little embarrassed for finding another designation. That I cannot call the thing which must *not* be called Prof. N.’s *theory* Prof. N.’s *practice*, I have established to the point of evidence in my book (p. 214 f.). But we might of course call it Prof. N.’s *opinion*, for an opinion is after all a “*neutral*” expression; or else we might call it Prof. N.’s *mystery*, which might be fitting for the reason that he is reluctant to come out with it, reluctant to “waste a word” on illuminating it, but is glad to shroud it in the draperies of ambiguity. Still, let it stay with “the opinion”! So, then: I have not reported Prof. N.’s opinion correctly; I have only, out of the Professor’s occasional writings and out of “*another’s*”^{*)} accounts, put together for myself “a something” that is supposed to be that opinion, and have not awaited the “authentic and coherent” presentation. That this “other’s” accounts are authentic in the *strict* sense Prof. N. will assuredly not deny: he knows that I can furnish the proof of it. But perhaps the fault lies in their not being “coherent”? They are given in systematic form, and their brevity is precisely their merit; for the opinion shows itself in them, stripped of the padding of phrases and the draperies of ambiguities, in its natural and naked shape, and the “crooked and skewed” cannot be hidden.

What I am supposed to have misunderstood in Professor N.’s “opinion” is said to be his *concept of faith* and his conception of *the miracle*. With respect to this it has to

^{**})It is as though a teasing demon had, unbeknown to Prof. N., wheedled this admission out of him. In the very first lines of his book Prof. N. concedes that I have *refuted* several other theories. The only theories I have treated besides Nielsen’s are Martensen’s and Kierkegaard’s. But now I have made it clear that Nielsen’s theory stands in such a relation to Kierkegaard’s that the refutation of the latter is also the refutation of the former, while the relation certainly cannot be reversed. That admission therefore made it superfluous for Prof. N. to write 52 pages; he could have been content with 3 lines.

^{*)}*Nomina sunt odiosa!*

a remarkable degree escaped Prof. N. what has not escaped me: that velleities are not sufficient. I have, in the survey of Prof. N.'s opinion, expressly brought out (p. 127) that he *seeks* to get cognition and thought into the will, to which faith leads back; but I have in the criticism of the same opinion pointed out (e.g. pp. 196, 199) that this striving comes to no more than a velleity, because the *absolute heterogeneity* makes that presence of cognition in the will an empty phrase, a bare postulate^{*)}. And it stands the same way with the conception of *the miracle*. A run is made at getting a lawfulness in: the miracle-working will of God is to be at one and the same time one with the laws and raised above the laws, and by this run one would so gladly keep off the awkward conflict, the conflict between faith and knowledge. But the miracle-working God is for N., as I have shown, "the God of arbitrariness," "the God who *creates out of nothing*"^{**)}, and this God who creates out of nothing abolishes the laws just as arbitrarily as he has given them; for they are for him only laws in that which is a nothing, and therefore themselves a nothing. It is only an empty word when it is said (p. 52): "what is characteristic of the miracle is not at all that a breach is made in the laws, but that a fact *is immediately referred*"^{***)} to God's almighty will"; for precisely this *immediate* referring to the *almighty*, *creating* will expresses a leaping over of the laws, a *breach* of the laws.

So, then: my conception of Prof. N.'s concept of faith and concept of miracle is perfectly correct; and neither what the Professor *willed* nor what arrested this willing has been overlooked. And as regards the objection Prof. N. makes to the way in which I have understood his determinations about the miracle's objective actuality — that point, so highly vexing for Prof. N., which at once puts him in a passion — I need only refer to what Prof. N. has himself had the goodness to quote from my book. I have shown how Prof. N.'s presuppositions inevitably had to drive him to the attempt, in order to forestall the conflict between faith and knowledge, to *double* actuality, so that faith and knowledge each got *its own* actuality. But thereby Prof. N. came into the unpleasant situation, over against believers, of having to take away the objective, outward actuality which they require for faith's object, and which they cannot give up if they will not give up religion's historical foundation. Prof. N. thus stood between Scylla and Charybdis. If objective actuality was held fast "where it really constitutes an indispensable moment in the phenomenon of faith," then the conflict with knowledge became inevitable; and if objective actuality — for example of Christ's birth, death and resurrection — was

^{*)}Nor does it succeed any better for Prof. N. in the piece. Compare in particular the confused determinations on pp. 16 and 17.

^{**)Nielsen: Om teor. og prakt. Erkj. pp. 70, 74 f.}

^{***)}Compare: "*that in which the believer sees the miracle!*" (Nielsen: den gode Villie, p. 33).

transformed into a merely inner actuality, then faith protested. For this faith knows very well “how to make a distinction between outer and inner actuality”; it is not confused by phrases, and I have surely shown plainly enough what a world of difference there is in this respect too between *real faith* — the faith that is alive in works — and *the faith of imagination* — the faith that is lively in declamations. Prof. N. stood and stands, then, between two dangers, and can save himself only in the way the cuttlefish saves itself: by making it black around him. I shall follow Professor N.’s example, and refer his readers to the Christiania lectures IX and X, and then only ask them, with a little reflection, to read through the reply to Prof. Caspari in the Postscript; they will then understand how the device is applied: “to talk black.”

Prof. N.’s objection to my conception of his opinion we may then regard as dispatched. But once it is removed, the Professor has a new turn ready to hand, and one over which he seems to be exceedingly glad: by my criticism of “the opinion” I am supposed to have achieved precisely what the crafty strategist against whom I was fighting himself wished — to confirm what Prof. N. inculcates again and again: that the doctrine of faith cannot possibly stand before science’s tribunal, and that it therefore neither can nor will submit to science’s decision. In my rashness I have thus fallen into the craftily laid ambush, and my crafty opponent seems exceedingly glad. Yet this gladness might perhaps not be quite so reliable a thing; for Prof. N. sees himself compelled to perform some little feats of dexterity in order to convince others that it is well founded. What I have directed my criticism against is the opinion about *the relation of faith and knowledge*, a relation which, by Prof. N.’s own determination, knowledge recognizes, in that it mirrors the opposition while it comprehends its own essence. My *criticism of knowledge* is thus directed against *determinations of knowledge*; my tactics are thus, on the presuppositions, entirely correct. But in order that they shall not be so, Prof. N. first lets the thing I was not permitted to call a theory become “the *theory of faith* set up by me (i.e. Prof. N.)” — so it is a *theory* after all! — and then, by a quick little maneuver, lets *the theory of faith* become *the doctrine of faith*. And then of course I am convinced of having let myself be caught. But even if we now let this substitution stand, I have in my book established precisely how the judgment upon everything that becomes an expression of the human essence belongs in the last instance to knowledge, in virtue of knowledge’s relation to the essence; I have not postulated it, as N. asserts (the piece, p. 8), but have furnished the “fundamental proof” in both *direct* and *indirect* form, and established the validity of the proof from knowledge^{*)}.

^{*)}See in my book the developments summed up on p. 210 f., cf. p. 169.

Prof. N.'s gladness over the crafty turn was thus short-lived; he must now set about carrying out the retreat, and it is then to be covered only by a little offensive movement. By that movement it first becomes quite interesting that Prof. N. comes to commit a tactical error of the same kind as the one he wished above to foist upon me. For even if the "offensive thrust" had turned out ever so successfully, even if he had annihilated everything I had given through my criticism by way of positive contributions to a psychological and metaphysical theory, Prof. N. would still be no nearer. He would have stood face to face with the impossibility of holding fast the "*absolute heterogeneity*," that determination which carries Prof. N.'s whole theory — now we may of course call it *theory* again! — and with which it stands and falls. And when he then gave it up — which he was perhaps by now not so disinclined to do, if it could be done in a tactful way — and got himself a new theory put together which was to lead to the same goal as the old, he would stand face to face with the insoluble problem of how, when knowledge's normative validity for the whole of personality is denied, there can be found a norm which on the field of the ethical and the religious makes a separation between the true and the untrue, between personality's true and essential demand and the individual's untrue striving^{**}). I have in my book pointed out the impossibility of it: Prof. N. will be as little able as anyone else to establish its possibility.

However Prof. N.'s attack had turned out, then, his theory would have been just as little saved; my book's negative result would stand unshaken. But Prof. N.'s attack is so little dangerous that it can be thrown back with slight effort — indeed it has essentially already been dispatched in the very book against which it is directed.

Of the attack itself it will of course be only the chief points that I come to touch on; to go into the individual little turns, little witticisms and little inferences with large paralogsms will be quite superfluous in the face of any reader who is not either by nature very muddled or has become so through incautious enjoyment of the sort of logic that is served up in the "60 sheets"^{*)}. My first sin is said to be that I confound the

^{**})Cf. my book, e.g. pp. 169, 203.

^{*)}Thus I think I may confidently leave it to any reader who does not suffer from the above-mentioned natural or acquired weakness to come to terms for himself with what Prof. N. develops on p. 8 f. about *existence and theory* and on p. 20 f. about *the will's relation to the self and its self-determination*. One need only note what Prof. N. cautiously slips past, and what he, not very deftly, slips in, in order to get one's bearings. Just as calmly do I think I may leave to him the criticism of the astonishing consequences that Prof. N. (p. 24 f.) extracts from what I have said about the unity of a *definite*, particular form of theoretical thinking and that form of thinking which would be, on the presupposition, *absolutely heterogeneous* with all theory — "practical thinking." Nor would it be beyond him to correct for himself what Prof. N. infers from the fact that one personality can never become completely transparent to *another* personality, or to see what difference I make between Prof. N.'s "absolutely heterogeneous" faith and faith in the sense of the religions. Finally, it would surely not be difficult for him either, by the "example *instar omnium*" of my "empty plays on words," over which Prof. N. is so delighted (p. 50), to make the discovery that the emphasis

general's scientific validity with the objective, and that to such a degree that I do not see myself able to make a distinction between grounds of science and grounds of conscience, between a cognition of the law of duty and a cognition of the law of gravitation. And this sin of mine is the gravest, which is why Prof. N. ends his piece by calling me to account for it. But here I am so fortunate as already to have rendered the account, which may be inspected in my book, namely pp. 141–148. Only with respect to my lack of ability to make a distinction between a cognition of the law of duty and of the law of gravitation must I point out that this juxtaposition is Prof. N.'s, not mine. I have juxtaposed the theoretical cognition of the human being's essence and the cognition of the duty that is determined by the essence, which becomes manifest to itself in that theoretical cognition; and on account of duty's relation to the essence I have held fast the unity of theoretical cognition and *cognition of duty*, the significance of *theoretical* cognition as a necessary condition of the truth of action. If Prof. N. in his "development of the case" had not used the procedure which Dr. Heegaard so sharply and aptly characterizes in his little book, p. 29 f., but had, instead of the objective cognition of the law of gravitation, which "does not concern the world of personality at all, but only that of corporeality," put an objective cognition of what falls within the psychological — of the human self itself, of human personality and its fundamental functions — then the one who cognizes would not have been "so expressly called upon to disregard all personality," and then the "development of the case" would perhaps have led to another result.

My second sin is said to be that by a mistake I put the general concept of the individual will in the place of the will that is struggling for its independence. May I put a question to Prof. N.? When it is to be determined what the individual will *as individual* does in determining itself to realize in action what has been cognized, how shall it then be possible to *speak* of this act of will, if one does not speak in *concepts* which, as the expression of the individual will's essence, express the individual will's law? This is not to identify the general concept of the individual will with the individual's will, but to posit the latter as that in which the former acquires actuality, and which therefore

falls on this: that the mystery which, in Prof. N.'s opinion, was to *prevent* the mutual limitation of faith and knowledge comes precisely to *express* the limitation; and that the "fine" point about the "mystery" *not* becoming something mysterious is that a secret is no longer a secret once one knows *what its content is*. But precisely that is known when faith and knowledge are each other's mystery, and are present in one and the same consciousness. Here, however, the "absolute heterogeneity" — this great and fatal discovery of Prof. N.'s — has played his "good will" the trick that the consciousness which is to hold both faith and knowledge really is "split." Let one read in "den gode Villie" (p. 33): "when the believer and the knower" (who, be it noted, are the *same* individual) "*both* at once direct their gaze toward the mystery, the strife is composed and the extremes are reconciled"! — So, just as in the Elf-Dance the One became Three, here the One becomes Two; but the Two will, "on account of" the absolute heterogeneity, unfortunately not become One again.

has its valid law in it. When, on the other hand, Prof. N. speaks from his standpoint of the concept of will, there is this peculiarity about it, that this concept of will does *not* become a concept of the will, and is thus called a concept of will in the same way as *lucus a non lucendo*. For the will, on Prof. N.'s conception, becomes — however much he struggles against it — that which, by its absolute heterogeneity with knowledge, cannot find an expression in the concept. One would then in any case have to let the common determination, concept, comprise two absolutely heterogeneous subspecies, miracle do (cf. my book, p. 206 f.); but such a relation is an impossibility, and it becomes only an empty play with words to designate the absolutely heterogeneous by the same determination. Should Prof. N. wish to call his concept of will a “concept of mirroring,” I need only refer him to my elucidation of this “category” — mirroring (in my book, p. 148 ff.).

So we come to my third and last sin: my lamentable confusedness in the determination of the energy of selfhood and of the relation of knowledge and will to the fundamental concept of the essence. Here, however, it has happened to Prof. N. that he has in a very peculiar way misunderstood certain fundamental determinations I have given — determinations which I have never had difficulty in getting the youngest students to understand, and which the Professor too would surely easily have grasped correctly, had he not so immersed himself in his own terminology that he rightly understands only what is expressed in it.

I have, in the psychological developments in my book, brought out essence-universality as that which, in contrast to the particularity of the animal essence — a particularity that betrays itself in the life of instinct — characterizes the human essence. In this determination of essence, which encloses the determination of inner infinity, I have sought the possibility of self-consciousness — the possibility, that is, of that relation of the self to itself, that being-for-self of the self which, in contrast to the animal self's being-for-self in self-sensation (in which the universal is indeed present, but always as bound to the *individual* sensation), may naturally be said to have the liberated — i.e. the form of universality liberated from that boundness; and in virtue of cognition's relation to essence-universality (p. 137) I have ascribed to it the ideal primacy in the human spirit.

Prof. N. has now in a peculiar way misunderstood the significance of the determination essence-universality and of the designation the liberated universality, and in virtue of these misunderstandings mass of inferences of a quite singular kind (p. 26 ff.), through which absurdities are demonstrated against me. But as soon as the misunderstandings are removed, they take the absurdities with them.

Then I have, in my book p. 135, determined the relation of cognition and will to “the energy of the essence revealed as unity in self-consciousness,” and for the determinations I have given there I must hear a great deal of ill from my esteemed critic. First, I am supposed to have borrowed my “catchwords” — selfhood and energy of selfhood — from Prof. N.’s philosophy. That is a little surprising to me. Not only have I used these categories in psychological lectures delivered before any of those writings of Prof. N. had appeared in which he has *touched* psychological questions — anything coherently psychological Prof. N. has never given. But I also stood in the naive belief that selfhood — the Danish word for subjectivity — was a current category in post-Kantian philosophy: a category which neither Prof. N. nor I had invented or needed to invent. And as for energy of selfhood — an expression which I do not, for that matter, remember having come upon in Nielsen, who in any case, in accordance with the absolute heterogeneity, would not be able to make much of it — it is the determination of selfhood combined with the old determination of ἐνέργεια, which we owe to psychology’s founder, Aristotle. It is from Aristotle’s writings that I have fetched this determination, not from Prof. Nielsen’s; and although there sometimes betrays itself in the latter a striking unconscious inclination on their author’s part to annex what belongs to older philosophers, I can hardly imagine that Prof. N. would fall into the self-delusion of supposing that he, perhaps in his youth, at one of his many earlier stages of development, had written the psychology which has since for some considerable time gone under the name of a certain Aristotle. Of Prof. N., as I say, I cannot imagine it; but for his adherents — or adherent, for now one ought perhaps to speak in the singular — I dare not answer; he has after all already discovered recognizable traces of his master in Norse mythology.

Those “catchwords,” which I have thus *not* borrowed from Prof. N., I am then supposed to have handled badly in determining them more closely. I am supposed to have got out a peculiar trinity of energies of selfhood, whose confusion in Prof. N.’s description (p. 38 ff.) looks almost as frightful as the confusion among his fundamental ideas. But a couple of short remarks may perhaps show that the whole of Prof. N.’s consequence-drawing rests on misunderstandings. What I have said is the following: the fundamental determination of the human essence is energy of selfhood; in the unity of self-consciousness the unity of the essence reveals itself, and for the energy of this undivided essence cognition and will are primitive expressions, primitive forms of realization. The general fundamental determination of the energy of selfhood thus receives its particular expressions in the forms of the energy of cognition and the energy of will; in both these primitive forms the essence expresses itself in such a way that its unity is preserved — not, as Prof. N.

will have it, *split apart* in absolute heterogeneity — and in both forms the content is therefore *essentially* the same; for the content is a determination of the essence, and the forms' abstract opposition is abolished in that the determinations which express it point to one another and develop out of one another (cf. my book, p. 134 f.). The fundamental forms must, precisely as fundamental forms, reflect one another's formal determinacies.

When one compares these propositions with what Prof. N. has written with visible satisfaction and innumerable repetitions in his piece, p. 36 ff., one will see that the Professor might, with a little less heat and a little more reflection, have spared himself a number of un-shrewdnesses.

Should the reader, with respect to some single point — for example with respect to the relation of cognition and will at the imperfect stages of development and at their culminating stage, or to the *conversion* of the content of cognition into the content of will and conversely — desire closer information, I refer him to my book (p. 136 ff.), and in particular to what Prof. N. has left out in his citations^{*)}.

Beside the striking misunderstandings of which Prof. N. has made himself guilty with respect to the points adduced, the accusations of misunderstanding that he directs against me acquire a peculiar light. I have already shown how matters stood with my supposed misunderstanding of Prof. N.'s concept of faith and concept of miracle; and with a couple of words I shall be able to show how other supposed misunderstandings dissolve into perfectly correct understanding. I am, according to the piece p. 32, supposed in my conception of the will to have made myself guilty of so remarkable a misunderstanding that no one who "might reasonably be assumed to be able to read" would be capable of it. The misunderstanding is supposed to consist in my having traced Prof. N.'s concept of will (*sit venia verbo!*) back to the "immediate expression of activity of natural determinacy in the drive, the sensuously egoistic craving," and against this Prof. N. sets himself with hands and feet. But, as I have shown above, velleities are of no help, and with the absolute heterogeneity between knowledge and will as presupposition, the will, in its separation from the universal of knowledge, really cannot become anything other than what I have let it become. It truly does not help, in order to save a cognition and a thinking, and thereby the determination of the universal, for this will, to posit two *absolutely heterogeneous* sorts of cognition and thinking; for we have already seen that that is only to make the determination cognition and thinking an empty word. Prof. Nielsen has not understood to what consequences the absolute heterogeneity — this absolute

^{*)}Prof. N. cites on the whole somewhat carelessly. Thus the citation found in his piece, p. 22, lines 6—11, is given in an entirely senseless form, and the corruption is moreover repeated within quotation marks further down the same page.

heterogeneity, about which he is now so silent — must inevitably lead.

In another place (p. 12) Prof. N. informs his readers that I have made myself guilty of “more than one distortion” of his words, of “a thoroughgoing misunderstanding of the whole matter under discussion.” This matter is the relation between subjectivity and objectivity. The Professor takes on very strongly and uses several pages to instruct and chastise me. And what is the whole of it? A misunderstanding — not on my side, but on Prof. N.’s. I had, as a kind of introduction to the criticism of Prof. N.’s theory, illuminated the confusion in his conception of some of the determinations by which he expressed the fundamental opposition: the determinations existence and theory, subjectivity and objectivity. I wished partly to make clear why in the criticism I kept to another expression for the opposition, partly to illuminate from a new side the relation between Kierkegaard and R. Nielsen by showing what fate the fine and acute thinker’s clear categories underwent on coming into Prof. N.’s hands. I then pointed out the confusion and ambiguity in Prof. N.’s determinations, and the sophistical use he made of them. With respect to the opposition between subjectivity and objectivity, as Prof. N. determined it, I drew attention among other things to two things. The one was that, while the abstract opposition is definitively held fast, it is arbitrarily ignored that at the various stages of subjectivity the subject’s determinacy — as appears especially clearly at the stage designated as that of infinite subjectivity — is precisely in virtue of what has been determined as existence’s objective principle, and that it expresses this. The other was that it is overlooked that subjective truth is precisely the appropriated truth, and, in the appropriation, the truth essentially equally objective with itself. By not understanding that the last passage expresses the relation generally, and by referring it, in a highly arbitrary manner, exclusively to a single one of the stages named, Prof. N. gets out that I have entirely misunderstood his words about this, and that I have entangled myself in ghastly contradictions. As soon as my words are understood correctly, one sees that they presuppose no misunderstanding of Prof. N., and that they are perfectly correct. It shows itself especially clearly at the standpoint of Stoicism and of Hedonism that the subject’s determinacy expresses the determinacy of existence’s objective principle. This needs no explanation for anyone who knows even a little of the history of philosophy, and neither does it need an explanation that existence’s principle is designated as existence’s objective principle. And when the general proposition about the relation between subjective and objective truth is then applied to these two systems, the consequence is that the relative truth possessed by the individual one-sided system — which in its one-sidedness nevertheless encloses something valid — is the measure of the subjective

truth in him who practically appropriates the system's objective truth").

Thus, then, matters stand with my misunderstandings, and such is the character of the attack by which Prof. N., as by a rearguard action, seeks to cover his actual retreat. But Prof. N. does not make this retreat willingly; he has grown angry, exceedingly angry, heated, exceedingly heated. And this anger and this heat he must give vent to in many ways. Now I must hear ill of my "noticeable self-regard"; now because on "an airy substratum of essence-empty abstractions, skewed deductions, smeared-out") turns of phrase and short-winded remarks" I have "stilted myself up into a philosophical authority, a high priest of knowledge." Now my criticism is honored with the title of "empty criticism of words," and remarks à la Per Degn are ascribed to me. Then I am informed that I lack respect for science and any sense for it, and then at last Prof. N.'s benevolent mood culminates, in that he undertakes to seek motives for my conduct. About the last point I shall presently have a serious word with the Professor; one thing and another of the rest I shall here illuminate briefly — some perhaps slightly unwelcome side-lights will fall on my opponent at the same time.

Prof. N. would reduce my criticism to a criticism of words, lacking "all development of the case." This turn Prof. N. has borrowed from that one adherent, who has however already used it so often — first against Cand. Brandes, then against Dr. Heegaard — that it might now be a little worn out. The "example *instar omnium*" of "empty play on words" which Prof. N. adduces against me I have already illuminated above (p. 10), and it turned out to be a good deal more than a play on words. Conversely I have illuminated Prof. N.'s "development of the case" of the relation between the cognition of the law of gravitation and of the law of duty, and it turned out that it did not exactly develop the case very far. It would be letting Prof. N. off far too lightly if, every time his conceptual developments were shown to be false and confused, he could simply cry "criticism of words" and then "generally, in all generality" insist on development of the case. Thoughts are had only in words, and they would have to be very vague and loose thoughts that could not bear to be held fast in the verbal form in which they present themselves. And development of the case is not exactly Prof. N.'s strong side. Only let one not be dazzled by Prof. N.'s habit of taking up, in his writings, great masses of material from the heterogeneous sciences with which he dabbles; and let one be still less dazzled by his speaking pompously of "combustion of material in the fire-air of dialectic" and so on. The "combustion of

)To Prof. N.'s droll argument from the fact that a Stoic can "put himself just as securely into" the hedonic theory as a hedonist and yet not become a hedonist, I shall only direct the reader's attention: it needs no commentary!

)A hard accusation in the mouth of the man who has written the second part of *Grundideernes Logik*!

material” is very slight, and on somewhat closer inspection it will appear that in the great majority of cases there is no more organic connection between Prof. N.’s conceptual developments and the material taken in than there is in a zoological museum between the animal hides and the tow with which they are stuffed. But there are certainly those who have had so much tow put in their eyes that they cannot see it!

Then Prof. N. makes me into a second Per Degn! Well, well! Rasmus Berg could after all make Per Degn into a cock; why then should Rasmus Nielsen not be able to make me into Per Degn? I should not, to be sure, have wasted a word on it, had not Prof. N., in order to get an opportunity to place his witticism, dealt with citations in a somewhat peculiar manner. If Prof. N., instead of beginning the citation from his own book with the words “If it stands fast that faith etc.,” had taken along the nonsense that precedes it, and if he, instead of beginning the citation from my book with “The lively analogies etc.,” had taken along what precedes (p. 187), in which that nonsense is pointed out, he would have oriented the reader considerably better. And had he cited the note I appended in full, the reader would at once have been able to see from whom the Per-Degnish enlightenment comes.

I had said in the note, on the occasion of some *«lazzi»* of Prof. N.’s: “Nielsen’s examples with the ‘mathematical friends’ and the ‘friendly mathematics’ elucidate only the not very interesting point that one cannot without further ado, because an adjective can be predicated of a substantive, predicate an adjective corresponding to the substantive of a substantive corresponding to the adjective; that one cannot, for example, because one can speak of an insipid witticism, speak of a witty insipidity. That there can be ethical and unethical astronomers elucidates only that different activities of spirit can have the same subject without being capable of being made predicates of one another (as, for example, within the sphere of knowledge, astronomy and medicine, since there are indeed medically skilled astronomers but no medical-scientific astronomy); but it proves nothing with respect to an absolute heterogeneity, or to these expressions of spirit being predicable of the same subject without their essentially going back to the same principle, or without the same undivided essence asserting itself through them.” In Prof. N. one now reads (p. 50, note) the following: “Instead of elucidating something about the case, Prof. Brøchner has, perhaps on personal grounds, preferred to elucidate something about the words. The elucidation is ‘that one cannot without further ado, because an adjective can be predicated of a substantive, therefore, conversely, predicate an adjective corresponding to the substantive of a substantive corresponding to the adjective’ — an elucidation which, as far as the case goes, stands about on a level with Per Degn’s

elucidation of Imprimatur: ‘All the words that can be named are referred to 8 things, which are Nomen, Pronomen, Verbum, Participium, Conjugatio, Declinatio, Interjectio.’ ” This elucidation is supposed to be mine; but from the citation of my book one can see that the elucidation is precisely Prof. Nielsen’s. I must therefore concede him the honor of having spoken like Per Degn; but I appreciate his good will, and shall in return presently be of service to him with a citation from the same play of Holberg’s, to which I can imagine Prof. N. is drawn by a natural sympathy. But since I have come upon Prof. N.’s note, I shall permit myself to add a small remark. Prof. N. has grown very angry that I have spoken of his attempts in the burlesque, and he speaks somewhat enigmatically of “decency” and of “prim, hysterical, cantankerous old schoolmistresses,” and of there being no “impure constituents” in his examples — words which he seems to ascribe to me as mine, since he adduces them with quotation marks, although I have nowhere used them. The Professor seems to have grown a little uncertain of his aesthetic determinations, and that may easily happen to a man who has to study «*practica, didactica, tactica, homiletica, exegetica, ethica, rhetorica, oratoria, metaphysica, chiromantica, necromantica, logica, talismanica, juridica, parasitica, politica, astronomica, geometrica, arithmetica*» and much more — that one thing and another may slip his memory. When aesthetics comes round again among the Professor’s many studies, it will be advisable for him to refresh the “conceptual development” of the burlesque; the “development of the case” he will then be able to find in his own writings.

So we come to the Professor’s accusation against me of a lack of respect for science. This lack is established by a very remarkable proof, whose validity rests in turn on one still more remarkable. The proof, the incontrovertible proof, of my lack of respect for science is that I have used no more than 6 pages to criticize the Logic of the Fundamental Ideas — the epoch-making Logic of the Fundamental Ideas! I stood, and still stand, in the belief that it was perfectly sufficient if I briefly and clearly pointed out what an insoluble tangle there is in “the Fundamental Ideas” Logic in the fundamental ideas — precisely, that is, in what was to hold the work together — and if in a couple of examples, taken from points of quite decisive significance for everything of the book that has appeared, I showed the sleights by which the dialectic of word-play arrived at its results. But in Prof. N.’s opinion that is by no means enough, and the proof that it is not is supposed to lie in the fact that the Logic of the Fundamental Ideas is “no less than 60 sheets!” Striking, irrefutable proof! Remarkable scientific measure! Why does the Professor not rather state the work’s mass in pounds? Scientifically that measure would be just as good, and practically it would be far more useful — especially when the Logic of the

Fundamental Ideas, having ceased to be a compulsory article of use for the younger students, is gathered “in a place of its own outside literature” with its elder siblings: the theological “propædeutiske Logik” of 1845 and Prof. N.’s logical firstborn, the poor little acephalous thing, the system “without head or tail,” the speculative Logic of 1841, which “systematically” begins with § 11 and just as “systematically” ends in the middle of a sentence. The *petitio principii* of which Prof. N. is constantly guilty with respect to the Logic of the Fundamental Ideas is that it is worth the trouble at all to occupy oneself with this fragment of a logical (anti-logical?) repertory. Had Prof. N. not, immersed as he is in his criticism of faith and his criticism of knowledge, quite forgotten that there is a third and very useful kind of criticism — namely *self*-criticism — he would perhaps have gained a clearer view of his own performances. Prof. N. has obligingly furnished me with information about my talent; perhaps a similar piece of information about his own talent will not be useless to him. Prof. N.’s scientific talent is a talent for the special investigation, where the view of the totality and the fundamental thoughts are *given* him. Scientific productivity in the higher sense — the capacity to bring forth the great, transforming thoughts — he lacks entirely, and in the same degree the capacity to master and shape a whole. If he attempts the first, he attains only to repetitions or bunglings; and if he attempts the last, the whole at once dissolves for him into an ἄπειρον of unmastered detail. Therefore Prof. N. should never have undertaken a work like the Logic of the Fundamental Ideas, for it *had* to fail for him, because it demands both the capacities that Prof. N. so completely lacks. How he wants the capacity to delimit and shape a material one gets a striking example of in the second part of the Logic of the Fundamental Ideas. In the preface to the first part Prof. N. states that it contains “not quite two-thirds of the first ninth of the whole work.” One should then expect that what was wanting to fill out this “not quite” lay tolerably well surveyed before Prof. N.’s gaze. But as he sets about working it up, it swells for him into so formless a mass that, in order to get that supplement furnished, there will be needed, besides the whole second part, two more parts of 30 sheets each, if the same measure is to be kept. An unclear feeling of his lack of capacity for productivity in the sense stated above Prof. N. has had, and it has led him, at his many stages of development — or rather, during his many transformations — always to lean on more considerable personalities: first on Hegel, then on Martensen, then on Kierkegaard, just as he now, at his “supra-scientific” stage, leans on Grundtvig. In such a relation of subordination Prof. N. would be able, in the field of particular investigations, to accomplish something good and useful, as he has come nearest to doing in his Propædeutiske Forelæsninger of 1860–61. But when Prof. N. wishes to be

independent, and especially when he wishes to be the epoch-making reformer of science, then he makes a fiasco — as when he invented “the absolute heterogeneity” and when he wrote “Grundideernes Logik.”

There is then only one more of Prof. N.’s charges that I will discuss, in order at the same time to fulfil the promise I lately made him: the promise of a usable citation from Erasmus Montanus. By my unseemly treatment of the 60 sheets I am supposed to have shown not only a lack of *respect* for science, but also a lack of *sense* for what is truly scientific. Properly, the fault is supposed to lie in my not having raised myself to insight into “the relation between system and schema.” Here I shall now willingly concede — for one ought in fairness to concede something — that I have really not been able to attain to an appropriation of Prof. N.’s systematics. But Prof. N. has also evidently developed the systematic to a height unknown in any earlier philosophy. For Prof. N.’s philosophical writings are to so astonishing a degree penetrated by the systematic that one can cut them up into larger and smaller pieces, and when one then puts the pieces of the various books together by page number and binds them, there is at once a system. All that was still wanting, for Prof. N. to reach the “absolute limit” of the systematic, was that he should arrange his writings so that they, like certain cabbalistic formulas of the Middle Ages, could be read equally well backwards and forwards. Now, so that the reader shall not think I am jesting, and so that Prof. N. shall not again reproach me with speaking generally in all generality about the general, I shall now give a “development of the case” so “punctual” that Prof. N. can hardly wish it more punctual.

Prof. N. has, in the last 3 years, during which he has given philosophical lectures for the youngest students, issued courses of lectures through the book trade, different ones for each year. In 1865–66 a first and a second course appeared, one for each half-year. The one of these courses was formed thus: that “Forel. over phil. Propædeutik fra 1860–61” was cut through at p. 177 and the severed front portion replaced by “Forel. over phil. Propæd. fra 1861–62.” But now this latter book had only 164 pages, and 176 were needed. A whole sheet was therefore written, which was found suitable to give room for a raid against theology; it was shoved in^{*)}, two leaves reprinted, and then one had a “systematic” work. What had been cut from the larger book then became, after the last leaf had been reprinted, the second course — and was just as systematic as before.

^{*)}In this interpolated portion Prof. N.’s peculiar wit culminates: the wit that must *not* have anything *burlesque* about it. An elegant sample may be found on p. 174, where Prof. N., mocking speculative dogmatics’ doctrine of creation, makes a table with the “wholly created” Adam, the “almost wholly created and exceedingly well created” Eve, the “half created but not misshapen” everyday people, the “more than half created” heroes and geniuses, and the “half over-created and precisely therefore often misshapen” dogmatic talents. Tasteful witticisms, offered to young students by the teacher who is to represent for them “the science of the sciences!”

To the two courses were added a couple of short prefaces, together 11 pages, for the most part put together out of fragments from Prof. N.'s philosophical Propædeutik of 1857 and from the preface to Grundideernes Logik, part 1. It must be on account of these prefaces that Prof. N.^{**}) speaks of the whole course as "these *extracts*, among which are also found larger and smaller pieces of philos. Propædeutik, Grundideernes Logik, and so on." — For the university year 1866–67 a new course was issued, which received the title "Propædeutik og Psychologie." It was manufactured thus. The propaedeutic lectures of 1860–61 were again divided at the same place as before, at page 177; but the severed part was this time replaced by the philos. Propædeutik of 1857. Here there arose the difficulty that this book had 204 pages, and only 176 could be used. Prof. N. knew, however, how to help himself in an easy and "systematic" way: he clipped off the end of the book, and although it was the concluding and most essential portions that were clipped away, the "system" was just as good after two leaves at the book's beginning and two at the junction had been reprinted. As a supplement to this new work the students then got part 2 of Grundideernes Logik, and in the fact that they had to read it although they had never seen part 1 there was of course also "system." But the systematic attains its true height only in the two courses for 1867–68. The one, *Logik og Psychologie*, is simpler in composition. Pages 1–262 are cut out of Grundideernes Logik part 1, pages 279–482 out of the propæd. Forelæsninger of 1860–61. New is what has been set in front of the book with separate pagination (pp. 3–5), and pages 264–78, which are entitled Psychologie and contain among other things a short and thorough survey of the *human* soul-life, in 2½ pages, of which, however, a portion is taken up by a treatise on the soul's immortality. Reprinted are only the leaves where the junction has been made. It is interesting that the *very same thing* which in 1860 was *propaedeutic* represents in 1866 *psychology*, in 1867 *biology and psychology* — but that is of course in accordance with a higher "systematics"! — The other course, *Logik og Propædeutik*, is more combined. Here pp. 3–80 are cut from the propæd. Forelæsninger of 1861–62, pp. 82–177 from those of 1860–61, pp. 177–204 from the phil. Propædeutik of 1857, and then again pp. 204–274 from the lectures of 1860–61. New is a "*Grundrids af den formelle Logik*" in 2 (in words: two) pages, set in front; reprinted are the 3 leaves where the junction has been made. One is much surprised, in the middle of a development that is not divided into paragraphs, suddenly to come upon § 35 on p. 184 and § 36 on p. 190, and then to see the division into paragraphs cease again. The surprise is removed, however, when one recalls that in the previous year a stump had been cut from the little phil. Propædeutik,

^{**}) Cf. the preface to the one course, p. III.

and it would have been “unsystematic” not to use it for the sake of those paragraphs. It must also have awakened a fond memory in the author of the little system that began with §. 11. — The reader will now, if he has a sense for the “systematic,” be able to sketch the plan for the system in Prof. N.’s next course. For there are in reserve: of the propæd. Forelæsn. of 1860–61, pp. 1–82 and pp. 177–204; of those of 1861–62, pp. 81–164; and of Grundideernes Logik vol. 1, pp. 263 to the end. Here, then, only a couple of small gaps need to be filled; and if these were evenly applied to the “half over-created and precisely therefore often misshapen” dogmatic talents, to the stilted “metaphysics-people,” and to the “philosophical bullfinches,” it might well turn out very “systematic.” Prof. N.’s polemic would serve excellently to cement the pieces into a system; for it is very sticky. It was for this new course that I wished to recommend to the Professor the promised citation from Holberg. What does Prof. N. say to putting the following motto on his new course: “*When this book is bound in a Turkish binding it is called Donat; but when one binds it in white parchment it is called Grammatica and is declined like ala.*” (Erasmus Montanus, Act 1, Scene 4.)

I am now done with what one may, if one will take science in a “wider sense,” call the “scientific” side of Prof. N.’s polemic; I now pass over to another side of this polemic, and here I must speak a somewhat different language. So long as we had to do with Prof. N.’s scientific and literary conduct, we have not always been able to remain within the bounds of the serious: the object lay too far within the territory of the ludicrous. Here it truly held: *difficile est satiram non scribere*. But I now come with Prof. N. onto the territory of the ethical, and here one must speak seriously. It is of Prof. N.’s insinuation concerning the motives for my conduct that I shall now say a word.

There has in recent years been frequent complaint about the form in which scientific polemic is often conducted among us, and rightly. Complaint has rightly been made about the coarse tone which showed that our men of science were not always at the same time cultivated men. But polemic has of late not seldom taken on an incomparably worse character, in that it has taken to imputing reprehensible motives to opponents; and against this species of polemic, which has been particularly often used against Prof. N.’s opponents, a serious protest must be lodged. When Cand. *Larsen* in his day wrote against Prof. N., it was anonymously insinuated in a journal that the motive had been — a university stipend. When Dr. *Heegaard* recently wrote his book on Prof. N.’s doctrine of faith and knowledge, something similar was coarsely hinted in an anonymous piece. And now that I have come forward with my criticism, Prof. N. puts forward in his piece

an insinuation of another content than those, but no less offensive. Prof. N. will, after the well-known turn, *not* say that it is not love of science but a smouldering hatred of positive Christianity that has guided my attack on him; no, on the contrary! he will find it right that a vigorous rejoinder be made if such a thing is said. Prof. N. will *only* – in other words say *the very same thing*! He will only say that it is probably *not* from *scientific* motives, but from an impatiently hurrying zeal to “*come to grips with the faith of revelation*”, that I have come forward⁷⁾. Prof. N., who has so often clearly depicted the evil instincts of fanaticism, does not scruple to awaken all these evil instincts by throwing out an insinuation in whose truth he cannot himself believe! Let us, when we would bear the honorable name of men of science, first and foremost remember the obligation it lays upon us: to act as befits men of science; but a throwing out of that species of insinuation I at least cannot acknowledge to be befitting.

But Prof. N. does after all furnish a proof, “a proof from circumstantial evidence,” for his charge. If it had really been science’s right that lay on my mind, then I should merely – have discussed with Prof. N. the problems in Grundideernes Logik! So then! if I had wished to maintain the right of knowledge and of science over against theology, and over against a “theory of faith” which in equal measure corrupts knowledge and faith, then I should have immersed myself in endless logical investigations with this theory’s representative, while he unhindered spread confusion and violated science’s right; – I should thus, in a word, have maintained science’s right by *not* maintaining it. This whole insane “proof from circumstantial evidence” acquires sense only when an intermediate premise is supplied, which must surely have hovered before Prof. Nielsen. With it the proof would run thus: if it had been Prof. Brøchner’s intention to assert science’s right, then he would have had – *since Prof. N. is one with science, is its incarnation* – to immerse himself in those investigations in fundamental logic, and to let personified science speak science’s cause alone. In this way a kind of sense came into the proof; but, Prof. N. forgive me! I cannot see it otherwise than that it came in only through that in which there was *no* trace of sense.

With this objection to Prof. N.’s unwarranted insinuation I part from him. When I wrote against him, I knew beforehand of what kind his answer would be if such a thing came; I had “circumstantial evidence” enough. To Prof. N.’s address he has now received

⁷⁾Might the peculiar inference that Prof. N. (p. 11) draws from my words perhaps point in the same direction? I had developed in my book that the form of consciousness peculiar to the stage of the positive religions let a remnant of egoism remain even in the religious relation of love. This becomes in Prof. N. the claim that the Gospel is supposed to be a “product of hidden egoism” and “the Hero of Gethsemane the greatest egoist who has lived on earth.” I have taken Prof. N.’s inference for a great thoughtlessness; I should be reluctant to consider it something worse.

a reply; and even should he, in the need to keep the last word, write a new piece, I shall be excused from taking any account whatsoever of it, unless it is wholly different, both in form and in content, from the last.

Only a few words more to my readers will I add about my personal relation to the problem I have treated. It is almost 30 years ago, when I was still quite young, that the problem of faith's relation to knowledge first showed itself to me in its whole significance and became an object of my serious and constant reflection. I was soon led to a conception not far removed from the one I have expressed in my book, and there came a moment when it became my duty openly to acknowledge my conviction. It was then expressed unreservedly and without timidity, although this utterance had to cut deep into all my personal circumstances and to lay perhaps insurmountable obstacles in the way of a future activity for me. It was at the end of 1841; in 1843, just at this time 25 years ago, I then wrote a little book against Martensen on the occasion of his treatise on baptism. From that time until, a few months ago, I published my book, I have written nothing touching the problem that has occupied me without interruption; and in my now already many years of university activity I have treated it in only one lecture course (in 1858–59), and there from the historical side. I had therefore no "haste"; I calmly let my conviction ripen in me until it became certain to me that it was not only scientifically tenable, but that it could sustain a personality's life. And I would not venture to take upon myself the responsibility of merely tearing down, by an untimely communication, where I could build nothing up. But there came again a moment when I held it to be my duty not to keep silent. It was when what was scientifically worthless and personally untrustworthy pressed presumptuously forward, spreading confusion, and when it was proclaimed by thoughtless ignorance, in the manner of a market-crier, as the only truth. I then made the problem the object of the university lecture course that now lies before the public. In what spirit and tone it has been treated the reader now has the opportunity to judge for himself; and I dare confidently rely on it that no one shall be able to point out a trace of hatred or of want of reverence for that which is holiest to so many. I dare rely on it; for from serious and noble men, inwardly attached to the positively religious, I have received utterances full of goodwill and appreciation. And I dare calmly direct this question to all those who through the many years have been my hearers — also to those who have most passionately attached themselves to a conviction opposed to mine: whether I have ever as a university teacher uttered a word that could wound their feelings; whether I have not on the contrary constantly spoken

with reverence of Christianity; whether I have not honestly striven to show its superior significance in relation to those phenomena of spirit which at its appearance proceeded from a similar striving of the spirit. Because I seek truth not in that which has now for centuries sustained the life of so many generations of men, but in that which *eternally* sustains the life of the human spirit and binds it together in unity with its divine origin — should I therefore not know how to respect the forms through which the human spirit strove toward this unity, and above all the purest and most spiritual of these forms? Assuredly! no one can think so, and even my opponent cannot believe it; for we have often enough exchanged our thoughts on this matter.

My task lies clear before me, and undisturbed by attacks I shall strive to solve it. It is: to find, by the way of knowledge, that which brings unity and reconciliation into the life of the human spirit — reconciliation between man and his origin. On the solution of this task I shall work now as before, without passion and without hatred, rejoicing in the sympathy of those who strive seriously and honestly, with truth as my only norm, always open to clear reasons, but undaunted by the clamor of fanaticism and with calm superiority in the face of what is base.

Erratum.

Page 11, line 2: videnskabelige [scientific], read: subjective.